



<Code Club JUSL/>



DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY
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PayPal SWE Intern

Internship Acceptance Guide

A complete guide for aspiring interns

Student's Experience & Suggestions

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Year of Grad.	2027

Experience

Online Assessment

2 coding questions:

Hashing + sweep-line based problem requiring careful handling of edge cases and optimization.

Dynamic Programming problem involving prefix-sum optimization where brute-force solutions would not pass.

Technical Round 1(DSA round)

Dont exactly remember the question but somewhat like

Array of strings problem that could be solved using either Trie or Sorting.

Discussion focused on approach selection, time-space complexity analysis, and trade-offs between different solutions.

Technical Round 2 (System Design)

Designed BookMyShow with extensibility in mind.

Seat categories (Bronze/Gold/etc.) couldn't be hardcoded — the system had to allow new types like Platinum without modifying core logic.

Started by identifying the core requirements and features such as movie search, show listings, seat selection, booking, and payments. Created a high-level class diagram and explained the responsibilities of key entities including User, Movie, Theatre, Show, Seat, Booking, and Payment. Discussed relationships between classes (one-to-many and many-to-many), class members, and methods. Emphasis was placed on extensibility, ensuring new seat categories could be added without modifying existing business logic. The discussion focused on OOP principles, abstraction, modular design, scalability, and maintainability.

Hiring Manager Round

The discussion was heavily centered around my AI/ML and AIOps projects. Questions focused on project architecture, design decisions, challenges faced, key learnings, and the practical impact of the solutions I built.

Some common themes included:

- * Why AI/ML?
- * How I developed an interest in the field.
- * Real-world applications of my projects.
- * Technical and non-technical challenges encountered during development.
- * Lessons learned from failures and iterations.
- * How this internship aligns with my long-term career goals.
- * Teamwork, leadership, collaboration, and handling setbacks.

Behavioral questions formed an important part of the discussion. I would recommend preparing answers using the STAR (Situation, Task, Action, Result) framework, as it helps structure responses clearly and ensures you highlight both your contributions and the outcome.

One suggestion for preparation is to use AI tools to generate and refine answers to common behavioral and project-related questions. However, avoid memorizing responses. Instead, prepare authentic stories from your own experiences and try to connect them naturally to the company's products, engineering culture, values, or business impact. This makes your answers more convincing and demonstrates genuine interest in the role.

Throughout the round, the focus seemed to be less on knowing every answer and more on demonstrating curiosity, ownership, a willingness to learn, and the ability to communicate your thought process effectively.

Prep. Tips

- * Practice DSA regularly, especially topics like Hashing, DP, Prefix Sums, Strings, Tries, and Greedy algorithms. The difficulty level can vary significantly; some candidates were asked very basic DSA while others received more challenging problems. Having familiarity with most standard topics is beneficial.
- * Focus on explaining your thought process and discussing alternative approaches rather than just arriving at the final solution.
- * Revise OOP concepts, SOLID principles, common design patterns, and basic low-level design questions. Recently, PayPal seems to be placing some emphasis on LLD, although the interview experience varies. In my case, I had a system design round, while some candidates were instead asked DSA, CS fundamentals, or project-related questions in later rounds.
- * Understanding the purpose, use cases, advantages, and trade-offs of common design patterns can be very helpful during design discussions.
- * Be thoroughly familiar with every project mentioned on your resume, including architecture, design decisions, challenges faced, and lessons learned. Expect deep follow-up questions.

* Prepare answers for behavioral questions such as why you chose your domain, previous setbacks, teamwork experiences, and long-term career goals.

* Instead of only relying on mock interviews, try interviewing with startups whenever possible. Real interview experience helps build confidence, improve communication, and develop structured problem-solving skills.

Notes :

* The Hiring Manager round was heavily influenced by my resume and project work.

* My profile was AI/ML and AIOps focused, so a substantial portion of the discussion revolved around project architecture, motivation behind choosing AI/ML, challenges faced during development, and practical applications of my work.

* Interviewers were generally interested in understanding thought process, problem-solving ability, and learning mindset rather than evaluating only technical knowledge.

* Clear communication and structured explanations played an important role throughout the process. Treat the interview as a discussion rather than a one-way question-answer session. Interacting with the interviewer and asking questions such as "Am I thinking in the right direction?" can help keep the conversation collaborative.

* The process tested a combination of coding ability, system design thinking, project depth, and behavioral skills. The exact focus may vary from candidate to candidate.

* Overall, demonstrating curiosity, adaptability, and a willingness to learn seemed to matter as much as technical proficiency.

* One thing I felt throughout the process was that interviewers were often evaluating willingness to learn as much as existing knowledge. It's completely fine if you don't immediately know the answer to a question. What matters is how you think about the problem, ask clarifying questions, and approach learning something unfamiliar. If you're stuck, communicate your thought process, discuss how you would explore the problem, and engage with the interviewer. Questions like "If you were approaching this problem, what aspects would you consider first?" can lead to meaningful technical discussions and demonstrate curiosity and a growth mindset.

✓ **Selected**
